

« We are pushing to improve on India's Tokyo Olympics performance. We are looking forward to the journey »

CRAIG FULTON

K. Keerthivasan

keerthivasan.k@thehindu.co.in

Since assuming the role of India's head coach in April 2023, Craig Fulton has significantly elevated expectations for the men's hockey team. Under his guidance, the national side has evolved into a cohesive unit, characterised by a robust defensive structure and a swift and efficient forward line.

In a short period of four months, the 49-year-old South African successfully guided India to a gold medal in the Asian Champions Trophy in Chennai in August. The side then secured another gold at the Hangzhou Asian Games, simultaneously earning a coveted spot at the Paris Olympics.

However, the Paris preparations commenced on a challenging note, highlighted by the team's performance in the 5 Nations tournament in Valencia last December.

It concluded with a solitary 5-4 victory over France. Germany, Spain, and Belgium were the other participants.

The men's senior team subsequently began a 15-day training programme in Cape Town on January 14. During this period, the team worked to improve its skills and participated in friendlies against South Africa (3-0), France (4-0 and 2-2), and the Netherlands (1-5).

Acknowledging the high

expectations following India's historic bronze in the Tokyo Olympics, Fulton remains optimistic about the team's prospects in Paris.

Can you begin by offering insights into the training approach of the Indian team?

It's a very complex question. Everything is geared towards peaking at the right time at the Paris Olympics. And making use of all competitions and blocks of training to do that. The Pro League will be there in February 2024 in India. Then, we have a training camp in South Africa. There will be lots of training in March and April. We again start at the end of May-June with the FIH Pro League.

What was your experience as an assistant coach for Belgium, winner of the 2018 Men's World Cup?

Belgium is very good. It was a great experience, and I gained a lot of

good friends along the way and learned a few good lessons, too. I suppose it is a more professional league that leads to the national programme. Working with top players and coaches, including Belgium's head coach, Shane McLeod, was great. Shane is a very tactical coach. He has a different approach. And with my own experience and by mixing it up, the results were great. Being part of the winning team was the cherry on top.

What were your takeaways from Belgium's club system, particularly its administration and culture?

Belgium has a national league that attracts the top coaches and top international players, which is always good as it brings different cultures to the DNA of hockey in the country. Lots of players with different cultures bring different ideas.

The National Programme is a highly professional initiative, and the Belgian league is notably strong,



I will get some of the younger players from India to play in the European League. That will be a positive step. I am looking to identify core players who can go to Europe.